

M.S. Engineering Management,
Northeastern University (2026)
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Subject: INFORMS Prize Committee - Prize for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice

Dear Members of the Committee,

I am writing in enthusiastic support of Professor Mohammad Dehghani's nomination for the INFORMS Prize for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice. I recently completed my M.S. in Engineering Management at Northeastern University, and in Spring 2025 I had the privilege of taking his course IE 5374: Applied Generative AI. The course directly enabled my six-month co-op as an AI Project Manager at Aosenuma, which I completed in December 2025.

The impact of Professor Dehghani's teaching arrived on my very first day at Gaman AI, when I was asked to build a Custom GPT, a Prompt Optimizer for the developer team to help them generate more accurate, functional code from AI tools. That assignment felt approachable because the course had walked us through prompt engineering as a structured discipline, role framing, context layering, constraint setting and iterative refinement. I applied those exact patterns, and the optimizer was adopted by the engineering team within the first week. The class is also where I first encountered the foundations of how large language models actually work, tokens, embeddings, temperature and text splitting, which allowed me to make informed decisions about model behavior throughout my co-op rather than guessing my way through configuration.

The second element that defined my co-op was Retrieval-Augmented Generation. Much of Aosenuma's work relied on RAG pipelines and as the project manager between client requirements and the engineering team, I needed real fluency. Because Professor Dehghani built RAG into the course hands-on with connecting embeddings, vector stores, retrieval and generation into a working pipeline, I could discuss chunking strategies, retrieval quality and grounding behavior with our engineers as a genuine collaborator. That changed how I was perceived on the team and how effectively I could run projects.

What makes the course exceptional is that it keeps pace with the field. Weekly GenAI news rounds grounded us in what was actually shipping in industry and presenting working prototypes rather than slides, forced us to build real systems, not just talk about them. The progression from understanding the underlying models, to designing prompts and agent workflows, to deploying functional prototypes, to demonstrating them publicly mirrors exactly the workflow I followed professionally. Very few graduate engineering courses can claim to have prepared a student to walk into an AI startup and contribute on day one. This one did.

The foundation the course gave me continues to shape the career I am building as an AI Project/Product Manager. Professor Dehghani is one of those rare instructors whose teaching translates directly into practice and I recommend him for this prize without reservation.

Sincerely,
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